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BOUNCING BACK

The 2008 one-day tri-series in Australia with Sri Lanka as the third team was a hard-fought competition. A lot of the tension from the controversial Test series that preceded it was carried into the limited-overs arena and the Indian team under new captain MS Dhoni were determined to return to India with the Commonwealth Bank trophy.

The pitch at the MCG on 10 February was one of the fastest I've played on. We fielded first and Dhoni was standing way back and still had to catch most balls at chest height. I was standing at slip, which was at the edge of the thirty-yard circle, an indication of the pace and bounce of the pitch. I remember mentioning to Dhoni, after an outside edge off Matthew Hayden's bat flew past me, that the pitch was going to favour the fast bowlers throughout the match and no chase was going to be easy.

Our bowlers used the conditions well and dismissed Australia for only 159. Ishant bowled beautifully again to pick up 4–38 and Sreesanth also did well, taking 3–31. At the break our dressing room was buoyant, though we knew that their fast bowlers would enjoy the conditions just as much. Sure enough, in the third over of the innings Lee bowled a fast short ball that flew off the shoulder of my bat over slip towards third man. Just as I was completing the single, Lee walked up to me and casually said with a smile that he was feeling very good and was going to bowl really fast at me. Lee has always been a good friend and while it wasn't exactly sledging, it was enough to fire me up. As he walked past I just muttered to myself that, come what may, I was going to take him on. It turned out to be one of our most memorable contests.